
Traffic, Search & Membership Performance Report

What changed in our audience over the past year — and how we win it back

Reporting period: 8 June 2025 – 8 June 2026

Data sources: Google Analytics · Search & SE Ranking · MemberPress · Kit & FluentCRM · BuddyBoss community

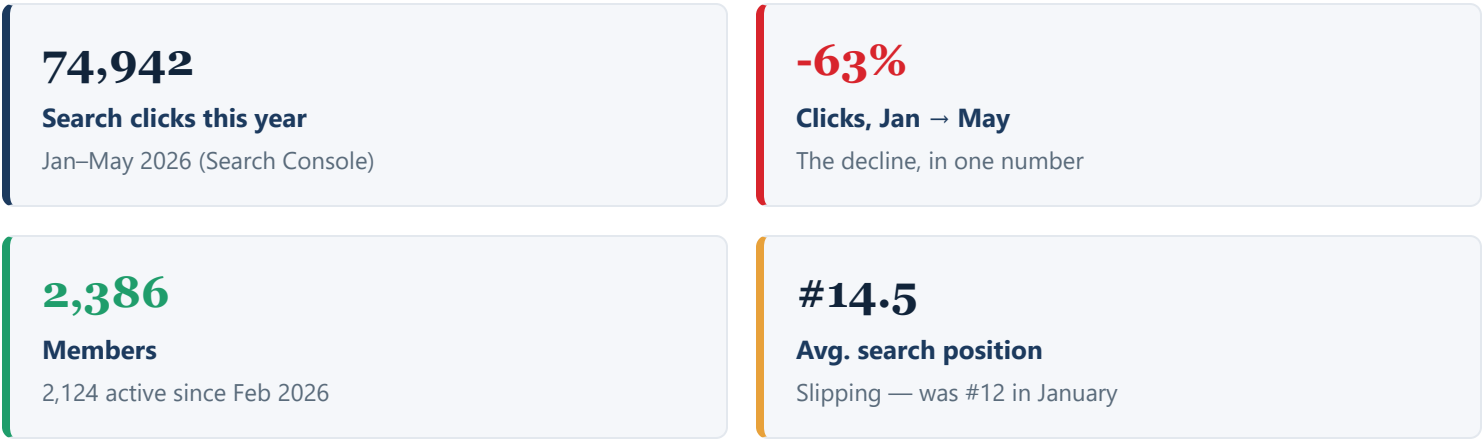
Compiled by: Tshepho Joel · 8 June 2026

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Executive summary

Our search traffic is falling, and the recent numbers show it clearly. Clicks from Google dropped **63%** between January and May this year, and our average position slipped from **#12** to **#19**. Three things are behind it: search itself is changing, we changed our own site on purpose, and people are getting answers from AI instead of clicking through.



The short version

So far in 2026 we've had **74,942 search clicks** off **10,273,767 impressions**. The trend inside that is the worry: every month this year has been lower than the one before, and May was our weakest yet at **9,852 clicks**. We're still being shown to people — impressions are huge — but fewer of them click, because more of the answer now sits on the results page itself.

At the same time, some of the change is by choice. In February 2026 we moved from a resource platform that mostly collected leads to a membership platform. In four months we've signed up **2,364 members**. One scoreboard went quiet on purpose while a new one started counting.

What is driving the decline

1. Google now puts AI-written answers at the top of many results, so people read the answer without reaching our site — even when our article is the source.
2. Our rankings have slipped: average position has drifted from #12 to nearly #19 this year, and high-value commercial keywords have fallen off the first pages.
3. We changed the website. Moving content behind a membership wall and retiring resource pages changes what Google can index and what visitors can reach.
4. We lean on too few channels, so any shift at Google hits us fast.

What is going well

- The membership launch worked: 2,364 sign-ups in four months, 95% of our search audience is South African, and members span every province.
- The funding story is our strength — our best pages, best emails and busiest community threads are all about access to money.
- We still rank first on our core terms: *sme funding*, *business advice* and *sme resources*.

Recent search performance — this year & last month

This is the clearest picture of the drop. Google Search Console shows what's happened in 2026 so far: month after month of fewer clicks, even though we're still shown to huge numbers of people. May was the lowest point of the year.

74,942

Clicks (Jan–May)

10,273,767 impressions

9,852

Clicks last month

May 2026 — our weakest yet

-63%

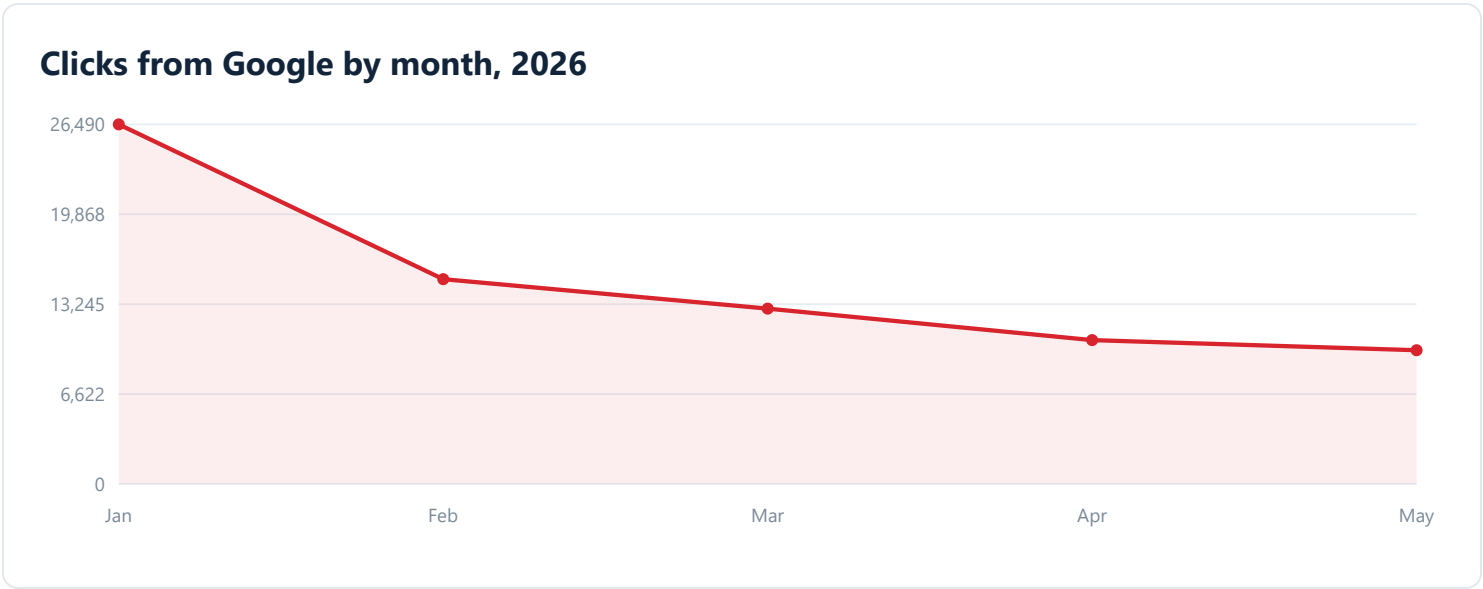
Clicks, Jan → May

Impressions fell 64%

#14.5

Avg. position

Was #12 in Jan



Month	Clicks	Impressions	Avg. position
Jan	26,490	3,549,601	#12.3
Feb	15,090	2,062,085	#12.7
Mar	12,916	1,828,103	#14.0
Apr	10,594	1,541,101	#14.4
May	9,852	1,292,877	#18.8

What the numbers say

We were seen 10,273,767 times this year but clicked only 74,942 times — a 0.7% click rate. Impressions stayed high while clicks fell 63% from January to May. People are still searching the things we cover; they're just getting the answer without coming to us. That gap between being shown and being clicked is the AI-answer effect in real numbers.

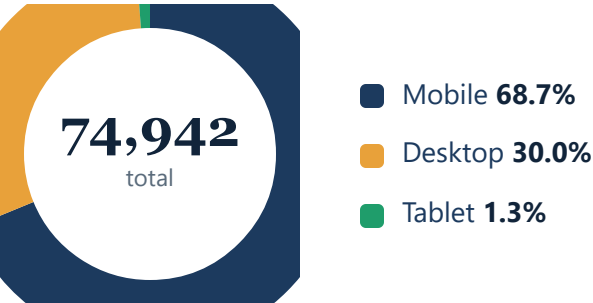
Top queries (this year)

Query	Clicks	Pos.
sme south africa	904	#1.1
sme funding summit 2026	524	#1.1
sme	519	#4.3
franchise under r100 000 in south africa	390	#3.3
seda funding	332	#3.2
cheapest franchise in south africa	278	#3.2
how to make money online in south africa	200	#10.6
sme funding summit	192	#1.5
sme finance	189	#8.7
seda	183	#7.3

Top pages (this year)

Page	Clicks
/10-cheapest-franchises-in-south-africa	4,050
/how-to-make-r500-a-day-in-south-africa	3,195
Homepage	2,264
events./event/funding-summit-2026	1,739
/seda-grant-funding	1,552
/non-profit-organisation-npo-funding	1,041
events: home	998
/requirements-for-a-liquor-license	982

Who's searching



69% of clicks are on mobile; 95% come from inside South Africa.

The pattern is consistent everywhere: **funding, franchises and side-hustles** bring people in. Our two biggest pages — the cheapest-franchises guide and the "make R500 a day" guide — plus the funding summit and SEDA grant pages do the heavy lifting. That's the audience telling us what to write more of.

The AI factor — why answers are replacing clicks

The biggest reason the clicks are falling while impressions stay high: AI now answers the question on the results page, so people don't need to click. There are two sides to this, and they pull in opposite sizes.

The traffic AI sends us — small, but growing

People who start in an assistant and click through to read more show up in our data. Over the past year ChatGPT, Perplexity, Copilot, Gemini and Claude sent us **23,707 sessions** (2.0% of traffic). It barely existed eighteen months ago, and these visitors engage better than average.

AI source	Sessions sent	Eng. rate
chatgpt.com / referral	11,191	63%
chatgpt.com / (not set)	6,109	63%
perplexity.ai / referral	1,831	61%
copilot.microsoft.com / referral	1,609	65%
gemini.google.com / referral	832	61%
perplexity / (not set)	578	66%

The traffic AI keeps — large, and invisible

This is the real threat, and it shows up nowhere in an export. When Google posts an AI Overview, or someone asks ChatGPT "how do I register a company in South Africa", the assistant answers using content like ours and nobody clicks. We did the work; we get none of the visit. That's exactly what our own data shows — millions of impressions, a 0.7% click rate.

What we do about it

We can't stop this, but we can decide whether our content is the source it quotes — and whether that quote earns a click. That means writing what an AI can't fully answer: first-hand reporting, local detail, named sources, real South African examples. The next section is the brief for the writing team.

Writing for humans in an AI world

If AI is going to read and summarise our articles, our writing has to do the one thing a machine can't fake: sound like a person who actually knows South African business. When our content reads like the average of everything online, an AI can reproduce it perfectly — so there's no reason to visit us. Distinctive, first-hand writing is both more trustworthy and harder to copy. It's our moat.

Do this

- Answer the question in the first two sentences, then earn the rest of the read.
- Use real names, real rands, real places. "R350 a month" beats "affordable".
- Quote actual founders, lenders and officials — first-hand voices can't be summarised away.
- Be specific to South Africa: CIPC, SARS, B-BBEE, SEDA, the actual forms.
- Write short sentences. Take a position and back it.

Not this

- Don't open with throat-clearing ("In today's fast-paced business world...").
- Don't pad with synonyms and lists that say nothing.
- Don't use the corporate-AI vocabulary below — it's a tell.
- Don't write generic advice that fits any country. That's what AI does best.
- Don't end with a hollow "In conclusion" summary. Stop when you're done.

Words to retire — three in a paragraph means rewrite it

delve
leverage
tapestry
robust
seamless
navigate the
realm
underscore
testament to

landscape
foster
elevate
unlock
harness
pivotal
crucial
vibrant
game-changer

in today's fast-paced world
it's worth noting
dive into
a myriad of
plethora
cutting-edge
ever-evolving

moreover
furthermore
in conclusion
unleash
empower
streamline
holistic
synergy

Reach for these instead

use
real example
named source
local detail
what it costs
who to call
the catch
one founder told us

here's the number
we checked
the short answer
what nobody tells you

The five-second test for every article

Before it publishes, ask: could ChatGPT have written this exact paragraph without leaving the room? If yes, it isn't ours yet. Add the name, the number or the local detail only a South African business title would have. That one habit is the difference between being summarised and being sought out.

Rankings & the keywords we're losing

The click data has a cause: our positions are slipping. Across the 151 keywords we track on Google South Africa, **56 moved down** over the period against only **15 up**. And the losses are concentrated in the terms that matter most — the commercial ones.

56

Keywords down

vs 15 up

4.6%

Search visibility

Low — room to grow

#29

Avg. tracked position

Page 3 territory

16

Keywords in top 3

Our defensible core

Dropped — high-value, commercial

Keyword	Now
business for sale in south africa	#100
finance for sme	#70
point of sale systems south africa	#100
business budget	#100
Business Cooperative	#39

Climbed — mostly informational

Keyword	Now
cattle farming	#10
Entrepreneurship	#28
crop farming	#22
starting a business	#11
commercial law	#38

Terms like *finance for sme* and *business for sale in south africa* — searches by people ready to spend — have fallen to page ten. The keywords that rose are informational ones an AI answer now intercepts. But it's not all retreat: we still hold the top spot on the terms below.

We rank #1–2 for	Position
trucking business in south africa	#1
business advice	#1
sme resources	#1
backroom rental business	#1
sme funding	#2

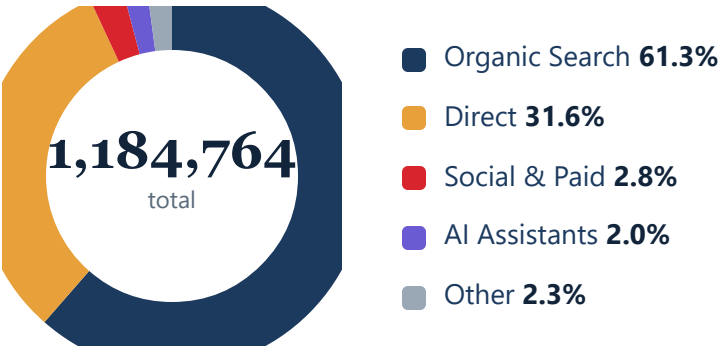
Where I'd put the effort

Defend the commercial keywords. Winning back 'finance for sme' and 'business for sale in south africa' is worth more than a dozen informational gains, because those searchers convert — for us and for the partners who fund us.

The past year in brief

For context behind the recent numbers, here's the full twelve months in one page. The story is concentration: two channels carry almost everything, which is exactly why a shift at Google hurts so fast.

Sessions by channel (12 months)



Top sources

Source	Sessions	Share
google / organic	636,524	53.7%
(direct) / (none)	374,310	31.6%
bing / organic	86,914	7.3%
chatgpt.com / referral	11,191	0.9%
m.facebook.com / referral	7,967	0.7%
(not set)	7,666	0.6%
chatgpt.com / (not set)	6,109	0.5%
fb / paid	5,285	0.4%

Organic search and direct together are about **85.3%** of all 1,184,764 sessions. Bing quietly sends 86,914 a year and feeds Microsoft Copilot, so it's worth a little attention. One easy win: roughly a third of traffic lands in untracked "direct" — tagging our newsletter, social and partner links would move it into channels we can actually credit. And where people do read us, they stay: a 58.7% engagement rate is healthy for a content site.

From resources to membership: the pivot

Some of what looks like decline is a change we made on purpose. In February 2026 we changed what SME South Africa fundamentally is.

Before — resource platform

- Free templates and tools, open to all.
- Measured in leads and newsletter sign-ups.
- Dozens of lead-capture forms.

After — membership platform

- Members create an account and log in.
- Measured in sign-ups, activation and retention.
- Lead forms retired in favour of joining.

The most important point in this report

When the model changed, the old metrics fell by design — form submissions are down 54.6% largely because we switched the forms off. Meanwhile a new metric started climbing: 2,364 members in four months. Judging the new platform on the old scoreboard tells the wrong story.

The pivot is the right call — membership is the more durable business — but it has real costs we should manage: gated content can't rank, relaunches briefly unsettle Google, and every retired page was a door into the site. Keep enough on the open web to attract; reserve the depth for members.

Membership growth & activation

The membership platform is four months old and has already gathered **2,386 members**, 2,124 active. We didn't start from scratch — we turned the audience we already had, our daily visitors and email subscribers, into members, 2,364 of them in four months.

2,386

Total members

Since Feb 2026

405

Joined last month

May 2026

~591

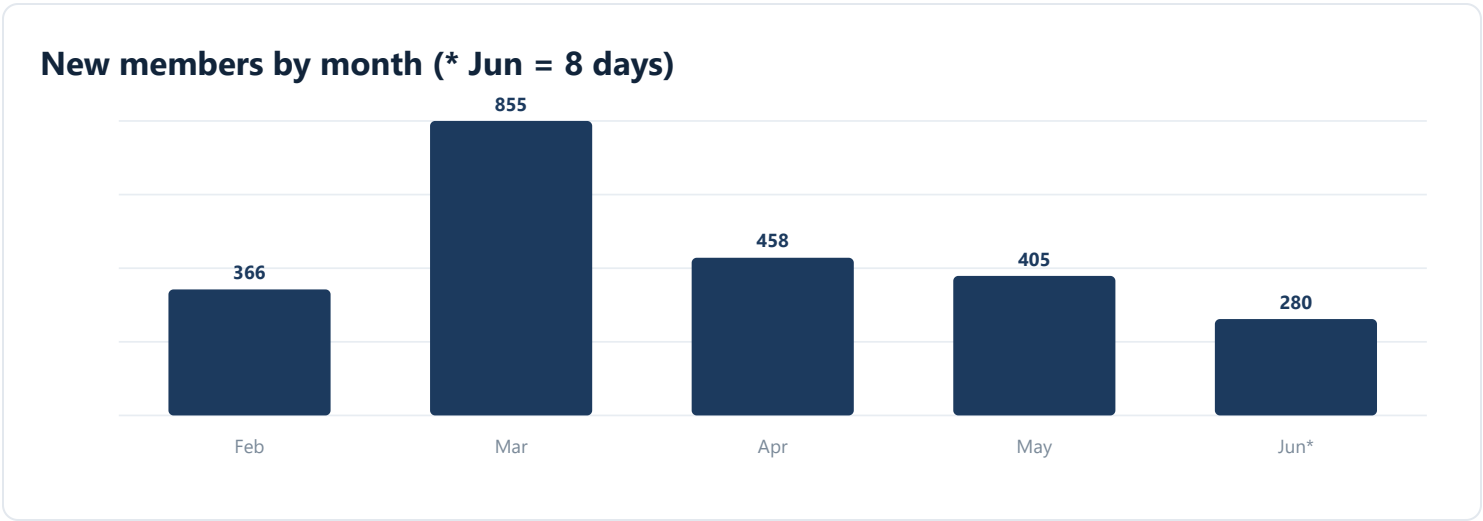
Members / month

Steady run-rate

30.9%

Never logged in

737 joined, didn't return



March peaked at 855 — the launch burst you'd expect — and intake has since settled into a steady 400–460 a month. But here's the catch: about **30.9%** of members have **never logged in** after signing up, and most of the rest logged in once. The sign-up flow works; the first week doesn't yet give people a reason to come back.

The cheapest win we have

Winning back the 737 members who never logged in costs a welcome email sequence and one genuinely useful members-only thing in week one — funding is the obvious theme. That would lift activation more than any new traffic campaign, because these people already raised their hand.

Who our members are

Beyond the headcount, we now know quite a lot about the businesses behind our members. The picture is consistent and useful: we serve **early-stage, owner-run small businesses** who are hungry for funding and connection. That's exactly the audience our content, our funding summit and our partners care about.

75%

Owner-led

Owners, directors & partners

82%

Solo or 2–10 staff

Micro and small businesses

63%

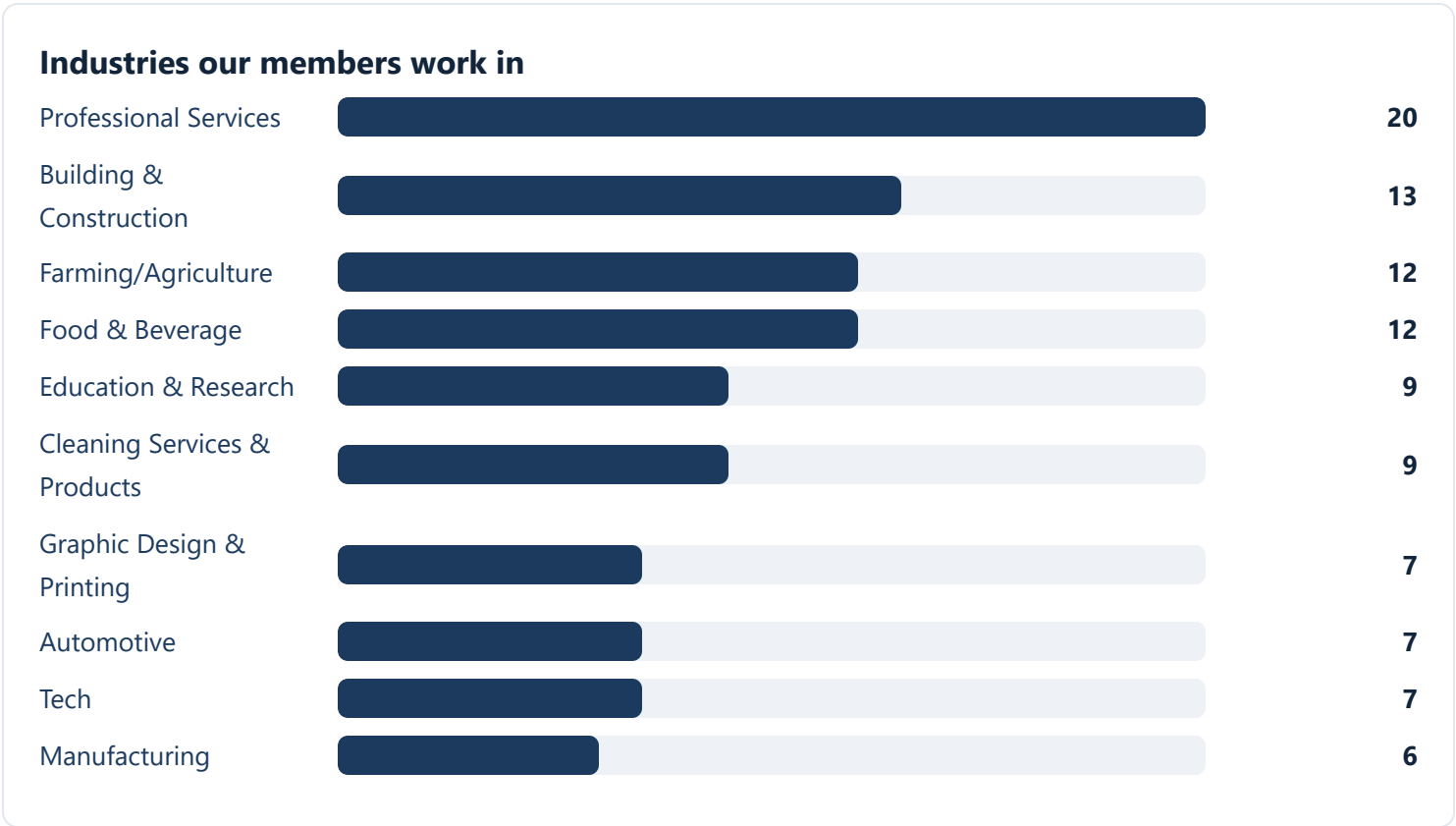
Turn over under R50K/mo

Early-stage and growing

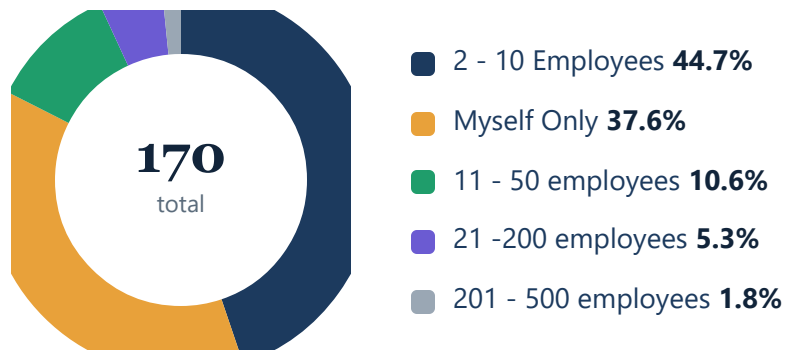
Professional Services

Top industry

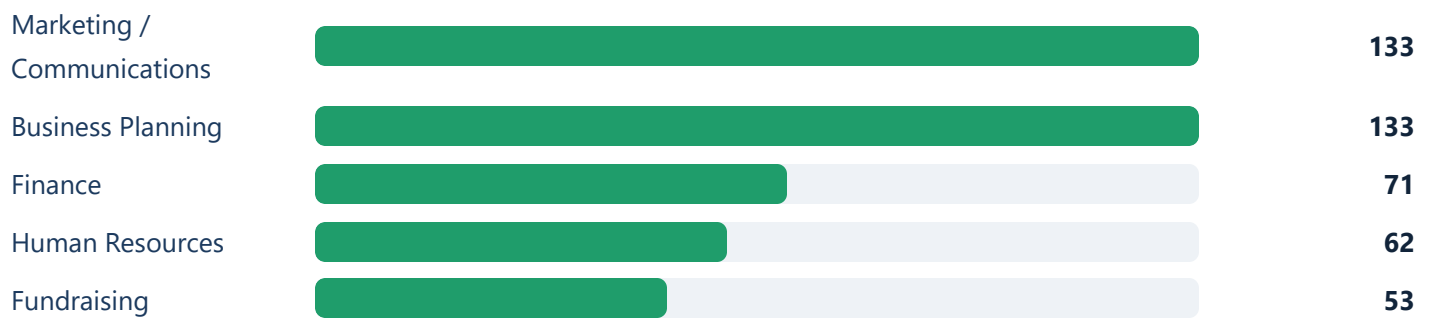
Then construction & agri



Company size



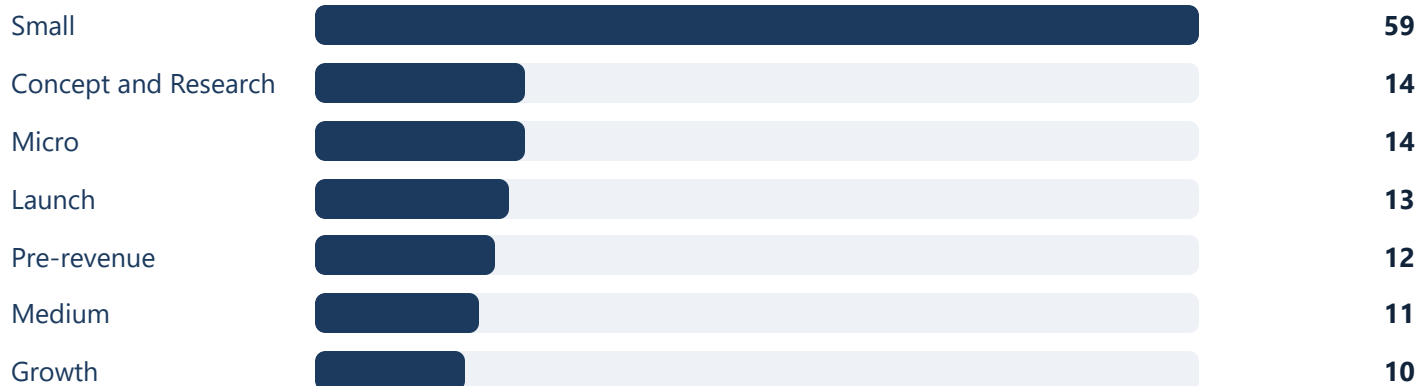
Skills they bring



What they're here for



Business stage



Monthly turnover



The takeaway writes itself. Our members are **professional services, construction, farming and food** businesses, mostly run by their owner with a handful of staff or none, turning over under R50K a month. They list **marketing, business planning and finance** as their skills — and they come to us for **networking, investment and mentorship**. Funding and growth aren't a side interest; they're the whole reason these members joined. Every funding article, lender introduction and members-only money tool is aimed straight at this profile.

Members across South Africa

Of the 1,971 members who gave a location, **1,701** are in South Africa and only **270** abroad. This is a genuinely South African, national audience — exactly what the brand promises partners.

86%

South African

1,701 members

9 / 9

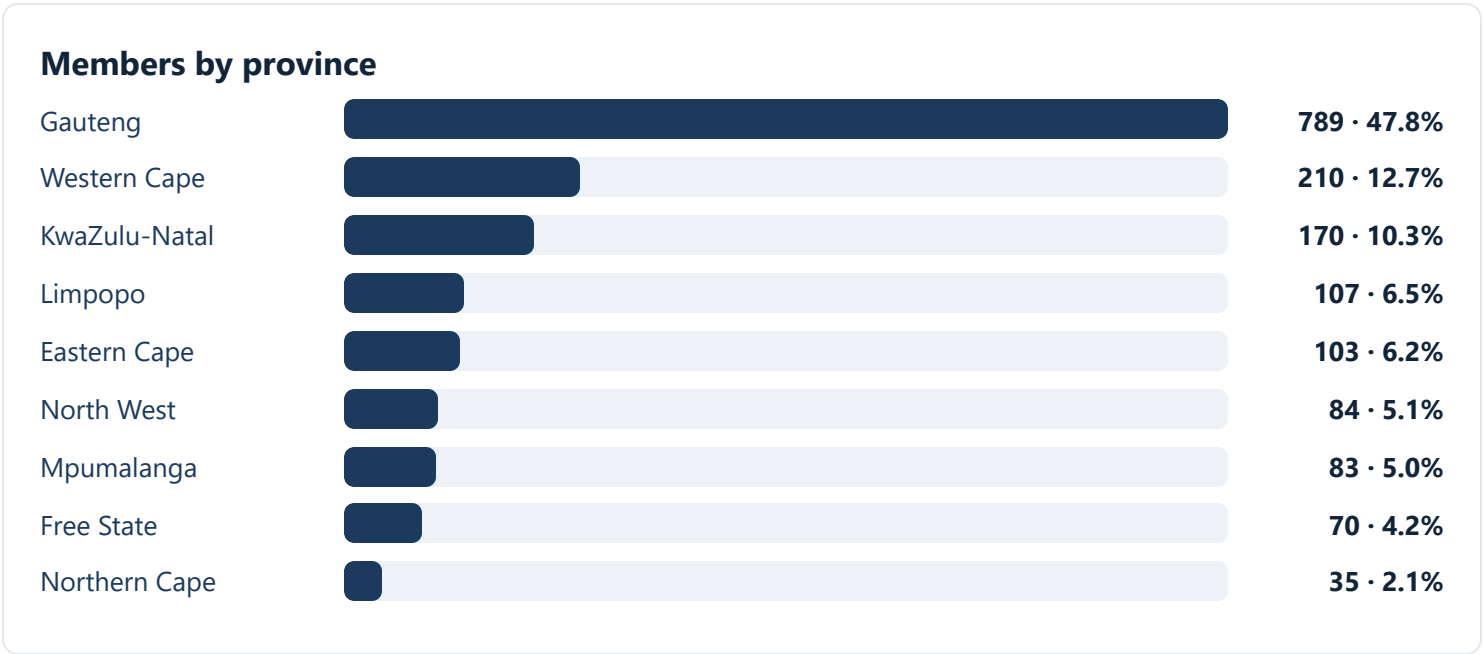
Provinces represented

Nationwide

Gauteng

Top province

47.8% of members

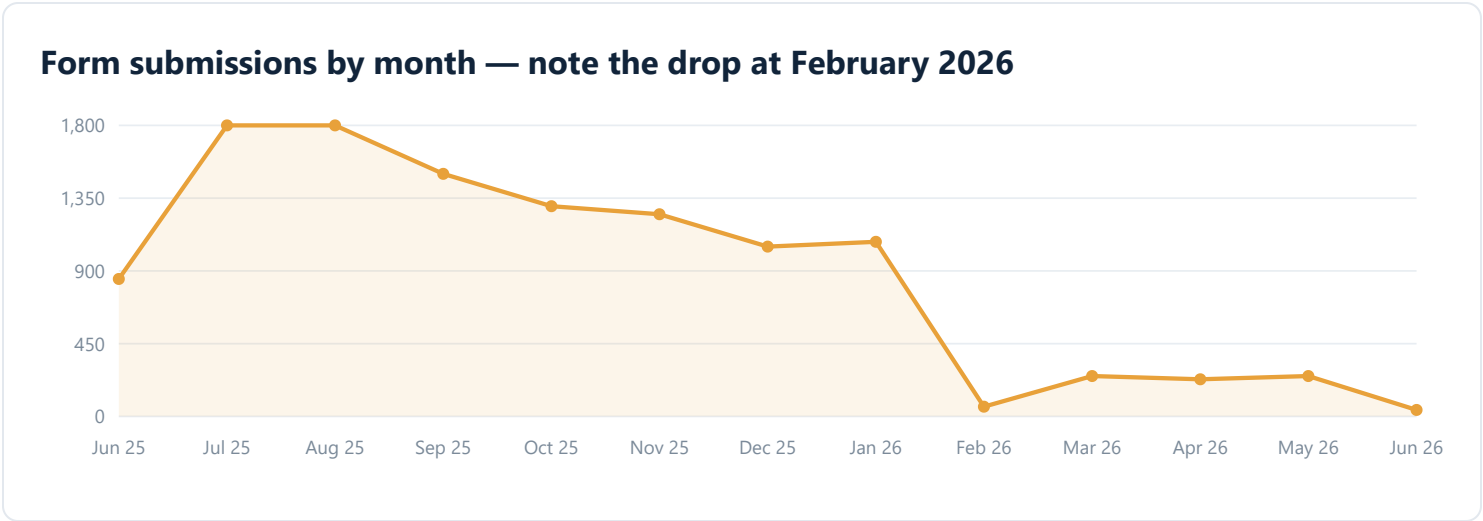


Gauteng leads at 47.8%, with the Western Cape and KwaZulu-Natal behind it. Top cities: Johannesburg (129), Cape Town (77), Pretoria (58), Durban (26), Polokwane (14). The opening is the under-served provinces — Mpumalanga, Limpopo, the Free State and the Northern Cape are real small-business economies with thinner numbers, and a clear place to grow.

Leads & email

Two channels that changed with the pivot: the on-site lead forms (mostly switched off) and the newsletter (now back on Kit after a spell on FluentCRM).

Lead forms — the cliff is the relaunch



Submissions ran at 1,000–1,800 a month through 2025, then dropped sharply in February when we became a membership platform. That isn't a vanished audience — it's us switching off the old machinery. The 54.6% year-on-year fall and the 2,364 new members are two halves of one decision.

Newsletter — funding is what they open

38%

Avg. open rate

Kit campaigns

6%

Avg. click rate

Kit campaigns

370,167

Sent on FluentCRM

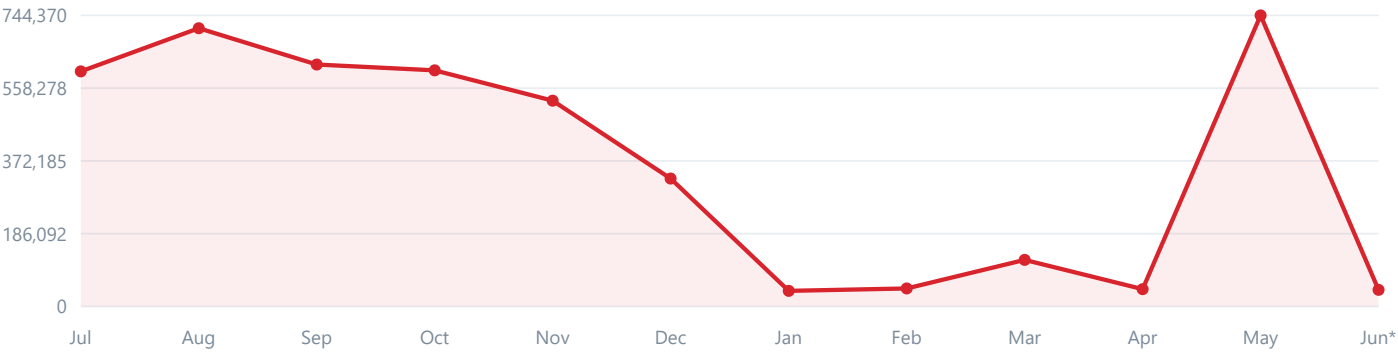
Feb–Apr, during the switch

21.1%

FluentCRM open rate

0% bounce

Kit emails sent by month (dip = the FluentCRM months)



Our best-opened sends

Subject	Open rate
Your Checklist for a Successful Business Loan	46.4%
What to Do Next to Secure Capital	42.1%
Post-Festive Funding Insights for Your SME	37.5%

Every top performer is about money — the same funding hunger we see in search and the community.

Inside the community

Membership isn't only a login — it's people talking to each other. This is the part of the platform AI can never replicate: real founders, across South Africa, helping each other in real time.

2,386

Community members

On the platform

9 / 9

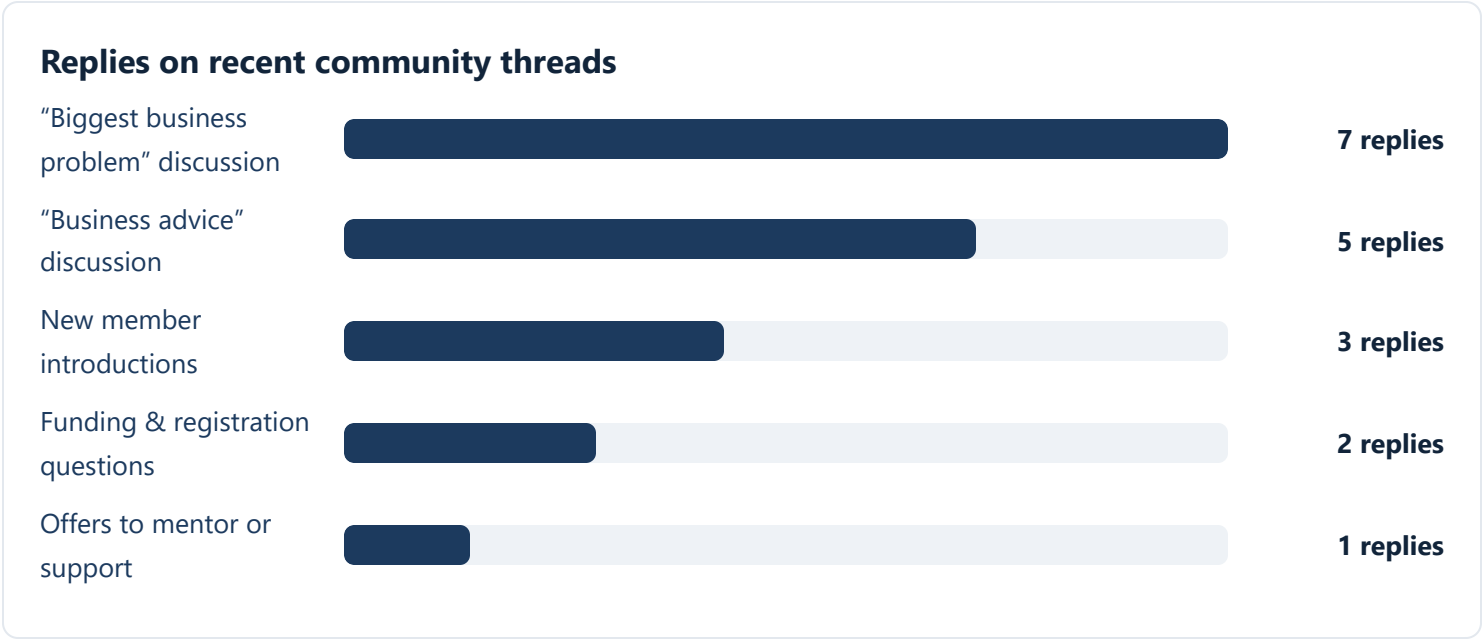
Provinces represented

A national community

Daily

Active discussions

Posts, replies, intros



What members are working on

A member in Mpumalanga running two small businesses is looking for funding to create jobs through skills training.

Member · Mpumalanga

A Cape Town member selling books at shopping malls wants to formalise and grow into a scalable business.

Member · Western Cape

A branding specialist offered to help fellow members stop looking “generic” and build a distinctive identity.

Member · services

In one thread, an experienced member walked a newcomer through the basics — CIPC, tax, B-BBEE and CSD registration, then FSCA licensing.

Peer support in a thread

One theme runs through nearly every thread: **access to funding** — how to register, how to qualify, who to approach. It's the same signal we see in search and email, and it tells us exactly what to publish and what members-only support would keep people coming back. Moderator prompts like "what's your biggest business problem right now?" keep the conversation moving.